

Constructing Grounded Theory

2nd Edition

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7

Memo-writing

Memo-writing is the pivotal intermediate step between data collection and writing drafts of papers. When you write memos, you stop and analyze your ideas about the codes in any – and every – way that occurs to you during the moment (see also Glaser, 1998). Memo-writing constitutes a crucial method in grounded theory because it prompts you to analyze your data and codes early in the research process. Writing successive

memos throughout the research process keeps you involved in the analysis and helps you to increase the level of abstraction of your ideas. Certain codes stand out and take form as theoretical categories as you write successive memos.

Memos catch your thoughts, capture the comparisons and connections you make, and crystallize questions and directions for you to pursue. Memo-writing creates an interactive space for conversing with yourself about your data, codes, ideas, and hunches. Questions arise. New ideas occur to you during the act of writing. Your standpoints and assumptions can become visible. You will make discoveries about your data, emerging categories, the developing frame of your analysis – and perhaps about yourself. Memo-writing serves diverse purposes. Putting things down on paper makes your work concrete and manageable – and exciting. Once you have written a memo, you can use it immediately or store it for later retrieval. In short, memo-writing provides a space to become actively engaged in your materials, to develop your ideas, to fine-tune your subsequent data-gathering, and to engage in critical reflexivity.

By writing memos, you construct analytic notes to explicate and fill out categories. Start by developing your focused codes. Memos give you a space and place for making comparisons between data and data, data and codes, codes of data and other codes, codes and category, and category and concept and for articulating conjectures about these comparisons. Use memos to help you think about the data and to discover your ideas about them.

The following memo relates what I first wrote after coding

Teresa's portrayal of losing her voice that appeared in Chapter 5.

BOX 7.1

Example: Early Memo on Connections between Losing Voice and Self

Losing and Regaining Self

It's been theorized that the surgery was responsible for shifting some things around, so things were just going to be different from that point on. That was difficult... healing physically and coming to terms with the fact that things would have to be so different from then on... I wasn't even myself anymore after that. *My voice was gone, so I was gone, and I'd never been anything but my voice.* [Emphasis mine]

In her statement above, Teresa (Participant 4) revisits a defining moment of eleven years before. She describes this moment as though it occurred yesterday. The meaning of the event hits her full force. 'My voice was gone.' A voice merged with self. Indistinguishable from self. All of her self. Teresa knew her life had changed at this moment and with it, the self she had been in the past. Perhaps time collapses as Teresa returns to the defining moment. Perhaps we see the self of the thirty-year-old woman become again the nineteen-year-old girl who faced losing the only self she had known and valued.

Meanings of time permeate Teresa's narrative. The past, present, and future take on intensified meaning, as Teresa's story unfolds. She had recounted the incident earlier in her story and in her statement above describes the surgery as a point in time. Teresa treats having

thyroid cancer as a defining event that separated past and present. Her surgery becomes a benchmark of time and demarks her changed self. It marks the reality of loss of the voice that had defined her and had shaped her life. As Teresa struggles with losing her voice, she juxtaposes the event against her past and future. Her story goes beyond an account of an 'unfortunate event.' [This story emanated from an assignment in Teresa's graduate psychology course on qualitative methods. The instructor asked students to write about an unfortunate event in their lives and subsequently interview each other about it.] Rather, Teresa tells a tale of devastating loss and of regaining a revised but valued self.

For Teresa, her cancer, surgery, and lost voice merge into an overwhelming experience that forced loss of self. The past shaped the force of the event and the life-changing spiral of events that rapidly followed. Yet she had gained both a stance and skills in the past that turned her tragic narrative into the beginnings of a positive new direction. (Charmaz, 2011a, p. 175)

What did I try to accomplish in this memo? I aimed to explore tacit and explicit meanings in Teresa's statement. Note that I brought her statement right into the memo and started analysis with it and the codes I constructed from it, including 'implying distress,' 'defining permanent loss,' 'experiencing forced loss,' 'voice and self merge,' 'losing a valued self,' and 'acknowledging suffering.' People with serious illnesses may feel loss of a similar magnitude but not express it. Teresa's statement, however, reveals the explicit connection she made between voice and self. I worked with the connections between voice, loss, and self and their magnitude. Moving to more implicit meanings, I asked, what role did time play? How did her past affect the present? To what extent did she view experiencing loss now as defining and redefining her past,

present and future?

Grounded theorists delineate the properties of their categories and define the category from these properties. In this case, the properties constituting the connection between voice and self in Teresa's narrative included 1) the essential merged nature of voice and self; 2) the degree of this merging – voice and self are indistinguishable; and 3) the necessity of voice for the unity and expression of self.¹ Did I believe that all of Teresa's self was lost? No. But I could believe that Teresa felt this way at the time. Teresa's story also told of regaining another valued self that drew on the kind of attentiveness, skills, and persistence she had developed as a singer. I saw connections between the two processes but the accounts provided more material about losing self, so I attended to it.

What does memo-writing do? Memo-writing encourages you to stop, focus, take your codes and data apart, compare them, and define links between them. Stop and catch meanings and actions. Get them down on paper and into your computer files.

Focus on what your codes and data show – and suggest. Take your codes apart and see what constitutes them. Grounded theory is a method that leads you to analyze the components of your codes and construct categories from these components. By examining the specifics, you understand the whole of your studied phenomenon, often in new ways.

Memos record your path of theory construction. They chronicle what you grappled with and learned along the way. As Lora Lempert (2007, p. 345) states, 'Memo writing is the methodological link, the distillation process, through which the researcher transforms data into theory.'

Methods of Memo-writing

Methods for producing memos rely on making them spontaneous, not mechanical. Before learning about grounded theory, you may have thought of memos as formal business communications that state policies, procedures, and proposals in official, frequently opaque, bureaucratic terms. In contrast, grounded theorists write memos to serve analytic purposes, as you can see in the example above. We write our memos in informal, unofficial language for personal use, rather than public consumption.

The methods of memo-writing are few. Do what works for you but aim to make your memos increasingly analytic. Memos may be free and flowing; they may be short and stilted – especially as you enter new analytical terrain. What is important is to get things down on paper and stored in your computer files. Keep writing memos however you write and in whatever way advances your thinking.²

Create a ‘memo bank’ (Clarke, 2005) of all your memos, which contains each revision of a memo. You can cross-file your memos as you refine your ideas, but do keep a central memo bank. Early memos often contain insightful nuggets that you can mine long after having excised them from more recent work. We cannot foresee what will emerge as significant in our nascent analyses.

Keeping a Methodological Journal

One way to expedite your memo-writing is to keep a methodological journal in which you jot down your methodological dilemmas, directions, and decisions. You will

find that your journal prompts ideas for memos as well as giving you specific details for writing 'Methods and Data' sections, articles, and chapters.

I recommend keeping a journal to engage in reflexivity and to avoid preconceiving your data. Following the oft suggested axiom, 'start where you are at' (Lofland et al., 2005; Lofland & Lofland, 1995), poses the potential problem of sharing unquestioned assumptions with your participants and failing to cast a critical eye on the data. Some grounded theorists who write about their own professions idealize them in remarkably uncritical ways that suggest an entrenched and unexamined value stance.³

Richard McGrath, who attended one of my grounded theory seminars, heeded my suggestion to keep a methodological journal. He wanted to avoid importing his prior experiences – and assumptions – into the data. At the time he began his journal, he had started data collection for his doctorate in business. Box 7.2 shows how his journal notes sparked his accompanying memo for his dissertation on managing ambiguity in Australian local government agencies (McGrath, 2012). Coding first is the usual route to writing memos; however, keeping a methodological journal can also illuminate substantive questions.

BOX 7.2

Richard McGrath's Reflection and Methodological Journal Entry

The focus of the study I conducted was Australian local government authorities. The adoption of this focus was purely out of personal interest and affiliation. I had entered my undergraduate degree because of my personal involvement with one particular local authority. Subsequently I had been involved as a research assistant working with various local authorities across

Australia and New Zealand conducting contract research. As such I had developed a close affinity to local government practices. However, I was conscious of the problem of being 'too close' to the study and this having the potential of influencing data analysis. In an attempt to avoid the potential of over familiarisation, I decided to keep a research journal to record personal views throughout the study. To illustrate the use of the research journal and how it was incorporated into later data analysis, I have selected a passage concerning the identification of the use of local government documents by staff to validate their actions and decisions.

JOURNAL ENTRY

Very interesting interview. Once again it appears that actions are linked to documents. As with other interviews, staff appear to validate what they do based on them referring to various plans and strategies. Documentation, particularly formal documents...sanctioned documents, are used as reasons for doing things. Staff seem to be more concerned with ensuring they are seen to be linking actions to documents.

Previous journal entries have noticed this. Re-read these entries....Think about what is in the documents that are of some importance.

I know all this though.

My own dealings with local government 'needing' research reports to validate their decisions...to use as evidence to support actions has occurred numerous times in my work as [a research assistant].

Am I seeing this in the data because of my own personal experiences???

I need to keep a check on this. Make sure I do not lead questioning in interviews to linking documents to actions.

Need to check previous audio recordings to see if this idea occurs from the interviewees or is being directed by me.

Following this journal entry I reviewed audio recordings and made the following short journal entry:

Checked recordings and there does seem to be consistent links between actions and documents. The discussion is directed by interviewees.....not me.

Need to keep this in mind for future interviews. Documentation is a key process. What does this mean???? Need to explore some literature around bureaucratic practices (Weber??). Think about the importance of this.

Later in the study it became apparent that documents were an integral part of the emergent grounded theory. A concept within the developing grounded theory identified in my dissertation focused on how some local government staff adopted a 'prescriptive' orientation to workplace practices. The following memo illustrates how this concept was initially identified. The memo also shows how the previously cited journal entries were used to assist in the data analysis.

McGrath's methodological journal accomplishes five purposes. First, having been involved in local government, keeping a journal helps him to step back and take a fresh analytic look at familiar organizational priorities and practices. Second, it gives McGrath a venue to capture his fleeting feelings and views and

to reflect on an interview shortly after conducting it. Third, the journal entry crystallizes ideas that he gained while collecting the interview data. Fourth, these ideas spur McGrath to review earlier data and compare them with his recent interview. Finally, this journal entry leads to a useful memo that informed his analysis.

BOX 7.3

Richard McGrath's Memo on Documents

Documents as a process to action

Local government staff use documents to validate action. But more than that, documents provide a direction for action. ... documents have a prescriptive nature to them. Documents tell local government staff what needs to be done...what the focus/purpose of their work entails. Providing recreation opportunities for people with impairments needs to fit into a process, a process indentified within a document. This fits into Weber's ideal bureaucratic organisation. Clear, objective, formalised processes detailed within documents ensures subsequent actions can be justified. The need to ensure a process is adhered to, to ensure actions are not created/crafted as a whim is substantiated through the use of formal, publicly available documents. Local authorities need to be seen to be objective, not favouring any particular agenda within the community.

Numerous citations occur within interviews linking the need to adhere to various internal and external documents prior to actions being taken. Documents are god-like. They appear to hold a reified place within the process of providing community recreation opportunities.

Analysis of Disability Action Plans and Sport &

Recreation Strategies also reveals the processes within which actions are to be initiated. Documents provide checklists from which to evaluate progress, justify expenditure, allocate staff and resources. This occurs across the variety of documents reviewed.

Need to extract examples and exemplars from documents to support ideas. Need to ensure this is not a personal view from my own experiences working with local government. Keep reviewing interviews to ensure the concept of documents as a process to action is not being forced.

The short memo in Box 7.3 does a considerable amount of work. In it, McGrath explores and defines how local government staff use documents. Through writing the memo, he identifies key properties of using documents: validating actions, directing and prescribing actions, focusing and organizing work, and evaluating performance. In this particular organization, the documents detail the process through which staff provide services. Consequently, their documents provide ready-made disclaimers that justify staff actions. Thus by relying on documents, staff dodge or deflect potential criticism.

The memo gives McGrath areas to pursue and ideas to develop. Each property of how staff use documents offers enticing possibilities for further analysis, should McGrath decide that he needs to examine these properties further to create a dense analysis. In addition, he can look for statements and actions among staff that show how they use and talk about documents – and further examine how the documents themselves guide or prescribe their use. Think about how this memo can lead a researcher to look and listen for discourses concerning documents.

McGrath defines a significant consequence of how local government staff use documents: they *reify* them. As such, staff treat documents as fixed and stable and view them as

immutable. Thus, documents take on a life of their own that transcends specific staff actions.

What about invoking an earlier theory? McGrath observes that these documents fit Max Weber's theory of bureaucracy. He does not apply Weber's theory directly but sees it as a source of comparative analysis for later scrutiny. Might engaging with Weber's theory mean that McGrath preconceives his analysis? Not necessarily. If he gives his data a fresh examination, fleshes out his ideas about them first, and treats Weber's theory as problematic, not as an imported truth, then McGrath's analysis can show the limitations of Weberian theory and the preconceptions in it.

Last, McGrath uses the memo to direct his research and to outline how he needs to check his ideas. Like the documents McGrath discusses, memos can guide, direct, and *commit* the researcher to actions as well as examine our research participants' actions.

Lindsay Prior (2003, 2008, 2011) is correct: memos are documents that guide grounded theorists.

Routes for Writing Memos

Professional writers have long advised having a notebook with you at all times. Their advice? Whenever you have an idea, stop and write it down. Similarly, Glaser (1978, p. 83) advises you to write memos as ideas occur to you. Memo-writing forms the next logical step after you define codes that you need to pursue; however, write memos from the beginning of your research, as Richard McGrath did.

Making memo-writing a habit will give you material to ponder, explore, revise, and sort. Grounded theorists have

different routes to writing memos. Think about the routes that work for you. Carolyn Wiener (2007) collaborated on numerous projects with Anselm Strauss and other members of his research team. She writes that ideas for pivotal memos arose in their team meetings (p. 302). Toward the end of his career, Strauss came to use transcriptions of team discussions as memos. Transcriptions can expedite the process for those who can devote the time or funds for them, if these researchers have a discerning ear and eye. Otherwise they may get lost in the details. Transcriptions preserve the rapid flow of ideas and may allow you to discern and develop subtle implications. If so, then your memos may grow in sophistication.

Box 7.3 gives suggestions, not prescriptions. Follow the writing routes that fit the way you think and work. Melanie Birks, Ysanne Chapman, and Karen Francis (2008) found it helpful to categorize memos as 'operational, coding and analytical' (p. 72) in the early stages of analysis. Their operational memos share similarities with methodological journals as they recorded their steps in the research process and the reasons for their decisions and actions. They define coding memos as those for exploring their coding and categorizing practices and view analytical memos as those for examining, explaining, and conceptualizing data. If such ways of cataloguing your memos help you, fine, but do maintain folders charting the chronological order of your memos that you can easily copy and cross-file for later comparisons.

My distinction between early and advanced memos only acknowledges that researchers have less data and fewer codes and categories to work with in the early stages than later. Our memos are likely to be more tentative and less theoretically developed at this time. Yet you may make dazzling discoveries early in your research as you learn about the world you study. If so, write as many memos as you can and make them progressively more analytic.

BOX 7.4

How to Write Memos

Prerequisite: Study your Emerging Data!

Identify what you're talking about – title your memo as specifically as possible. You may sense that the words you choose do not quite capture the meaning. Flag them. Think about them. Refine them later. Write now!

Early Memos

Record what you see happening in the data. Use early memos to explore and fill out your qualitative codes. Use them to direct and focus further data collection. Some basic questions may help:

- What is going on in the field setting or within the interview accounts? Can you turn it into a pithy category? Examples: 'avoiding disclosure,' 'surrendering to illness,' and 'losing a valued self.'
- What are people doing?
- What are people saying or trying to say? What do they remain silent about? What accounts for their silence? When, if at all, do secrets shape what's happening?
- What do research participants' actions and statements take for granted?
- How do structure and context serve to support, maintain, impede or change their actions and statements?
- What connections can you make? Which ones do you need to check?
- What comparisons can you make?

Have you found *in vivo* codes such as 'living one day at

a time,' 'vaporizing' (Morrill, 1995), and 'jumping through hoops' (Doig et al., 2009) to take apart and examine? A grounded theory study allows you to look for processes. The following questions help to maintain a focus on process:

- What process is at issue here? How would you define it? To what extent is it explicit or does it remain implicit?
- Under which conditions does this process develop?
- How do(es) the research participant(s) think, feel, and act while involved in this process?
- What slows, impedes, or accelerates the process?
- When, why, how, and under which conditions does the process change?
- What are the consequences of the process?
- Structure memos to chart observed and predicted relationships in your data and between your emerging categories.

Advanced Memos

- Trace and categorize data subsumed by your topic.
- Describe how your category emerges and changes.
- Identify the beliefs and assumptions that support it.
- Specify how the category informs action and experience. If relevant, tell what it looks and feels like from various vantage points.
- Place the category or categories within an argument.
- Sharpen your comparisons:
 - Compare different people (such as their beliefs, situations, actions, accounts, or experiences).
 - Compare data from the same individuals with

themselves at different points in time.

- **Compare codes. Specify their relationship(s) with your tentative category.**
- **Compare categories in the data with other categories. For example: How does “accepting” illness’ compare with ‘reconciling oneself to illness?’ Which categories should become major sections? Which should be relegated to minor status?**
- **Compare subcategories with general categories for fit—example: Where does “accepting” Illness’ go? At what point does it become an issue? Where does it fit into the course of illness?**
- **Compare subcategories within a general category. For example: What is the difference between an ‘identifying moment’ and a ‘significant event?’**
- **Compare concepts or conceptual categories. For example: Demonstrate the differences between the ‘self in the past’ and the ‘self in the present,’ compare experiencing ‘intrusive illness’ with ‘immersion in illness.’**
- **Compare the entire analysis with existing literature or the ruling ideas in a field.**
- **Refine the consequences of your analysis.**

Adapted and updated from Kathy Charmaz (1995b).

Memo-writing encourages you to stop other research activities, such as gathering data without analyzing them. Engage an emergent category, let your mind rove freely in, around, under, and from the category; and write whatever comes to you. That is why memo-writing forms an interactive space and place for exploration and discovery. You take the time to discover your ideas about what you have seen, heard, sensed, and coded and

then you examine these ideas.

Memos spur you to develop your ideas in narrative form and fullness early in the analytic process. Your memos will help you clarify and direct your subsequent coding. Writing memos prompts you to elaborate processes, assumptions, and actions covered by your codes or categories. They encourage you to take your emergent categories apart and break them into their components. Memos also help you to identify which codes to treat as analytic categories, if you have not already defined them. (Then you can further develop these categories through more memo-writing.)

No single mechanical procedure defines a useful memo. Do what is possible with the material you have. Memos vary, but you may do any of the following in a memo:

- **Define each code or category by its analytic properties**
- **Spell out and detail processes subsumed by the codes or categories**
- **Make comparisons between data and data, data and codes, codes and codes, codes and categories, categories and categories**
- **Bring raw data into the memo**
- **Provide sufficient empirical evidence to support your definitions of the category and analytic claims about it**
- **Offer conjectures to check in the field setting(s)**
- **Sort and order codes and categories**
- **Identify gaps in the analysis**
- **Interrogate a code or category by asking questions of it.**

Specifying each code and titling your memo accordingly focuses its source, content, and direction. Giving your codes specificity helps you to examine them in your memos, clarify the code, and see how it fits with other data and codes. Then you can revise, develop, or put the memo aside, as indicated by your data and analysis.

Grounded theorists look for patterns, even when focusing on a single case (see Strauss & Glaser, 1970). Because we stress identifying patterns, grounded theorists typically invoke respondents' stories to illustrate analytic points – rather than provide complete portrayals of their lives or even a full narrative of an experience.⁴ When you bring raw data right into your memo, you preserve telling evidence for your analytic ideas from the start. Providing ample verbatim material 'grounds' your abstract analysis and lays a foundation for making claims about it. Including verbatim material from different sources permits you to make precise comparisons right in the memo. These comparisons enable you to define patterns in the empirical world. Thus, memo-writing moves your work beyond individual cases.

BOX 7.5

Codes: Interview with Staff Member P-D in a Facility for Survivors of Brain Injury 319s

Initial ends

Acknowledging multiple reasons;
Repeating all-inclusive euphemism—'challenging'

Delineating reasons—stressing magnitude of losses: suffering rejection; identifying identity loss, family because of personality changes, children, home, job
Losing one's life, way of being in the world

Suffering massive loss; having alienated others

Misbehaving cloaks loss; misreading behaviour (by staff): acting up reflects loss

Confronting loss constantly; surveying probable pasts

Explaining all-encompassing loss

Being aware of devastating losses;
Losing one's prior life; having nothing left

Comparing self with others

Explaining emotional response

Interview statement

I: (3) The next question is thinking about why, um, patients with brain injury might exhibit challenging behaviour and you've, you've kind of talked a bit about that, you know, the processes in the brain. Is there anything else you want to add to that?

P-D: There's *so many* reasons why a patient might display challenging behaviour. Loss of identity, you know, loss, they suffer *huge* losses, they might lose their family because of the change in personality, families just can't cope with, you know, this changing person. They might lose their children, they might lose their home, you know, they'll lose um, lose their job. I think, I don't think enough emphasis is placed on that fact that these people have *lost* their life. And basically through that they have perhaps experienced a huge range, huge range of losses and because of their behaviour they may have alienated people so that there is just this massive aspect of loss that they all have. And again, again I don't think that there are people that appreciate that, that they are doing it because they are acting up, or they are doing it because they want something when in effect, you know, they might just be constantly thinking about how much they've lost. I mean um, well you know — *patient*, well — *patient* has lost *everything* she lost her, you know she had a flat with her, well she was engaged she had a, you know, a really good job, fantastic social life. And she's got *nothing* now, and, you know, quite rightly so that, she's, you know, on days where she's feeling low and sees people going off doing things that she can't do. Her level of arousal is going to rise, so if you even say wait a minute to her, it's *important* to her. And I think that's

Understanding the magnifying of small slights Forgetting to place patient's behaviour in context; staff bifurcating patient's biography Acknowledging lack of life Pointing out staff's overlooking loss Putting self in patient's situation Understanding patient's frustration with varied causes of loss Connecting patient's losses with current mental health Understanding loss of autonomy, dignity Placing patient's anger in context Failing to grasp meanings of loss Lacking empathy—staff	another thing that people forget it that, although it might seem a petty small request or something small that. People forget that to them [patients] that's, that's important to them and they haven't got much of a life, um (.) I do think that once people have been here a long time, I think some people do forget that these patients have lost everything. And quite frankly I think I'd probably want to be as awkward as I could if it meant that I would get somebody to talk to me. Um, if they can't <i>communicate</i>, you know quite often they'll lose their ability to speak, you know, they're going to get frustrated with that. If they've lost their ability to walk, you know it's just so many, <i>so many</i> different aspects that could, you know, it can impact on their mental health if they had issues before, or they might, you know, they might become depressed (2). It's just so, so, physical issues, things that they can't do. You know, it's somebody who was quite proud, you know, quite an independent person who can't wash themselves, is going to get pissed off with it. Something that people don't, aren't, don't get a grasp of through just working with patients every day. I don't think people really, I don't think the empathy is always there...
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From Tweed and Charmaz (2011, pp. 138–140).

Standpoints and Starting Points in Memo-writing

Where we stand and start analysis influences the form and content of our memos and, thus, our written reports. When writing early memos about an unfamiliar topic, we have the advantage of a fresh view and the disadvantage of having little background knowledge. To show differences in standpoints and starting points – and how our memos can vary – I present and

discuss two memos that have contrasting origins.

For the first memo, 'Explaining All-Encompassing Loss' (Box 7.6) I had coded and analyzed data from the standpoint of a distant analyst who was not involved in the setting. Inga Stewart collected the data from staff members who worked at a medical facility that treated brain-injured patients. She contributed a portion of her data for me to analyze in a co-authored chapter with Alison Tweed (Tweed & Charmaz, 2011). I had no direct contact with any of the research participants. I coded interviews and wrote the memo without prior knowledge about the setting or of current concepts in care of brain-injured patients. Compare the memo with a data excerpt and codes from Participant D's interview that informed it (Box 7.5). I saw Participant D's views of the losses patients had sustained as reflecting a carefully articulated account and as offering details for important comparisons with how other staff viewed the patients and their work.

BOX 7.6

Early Memo: Explaining All-Encompassing Loss

Explaining all-encompassing loss means making explicit unknown or forgotten meanings of the magnitude of patients' loss. Explaining here means pointing out types of loss patients have experienced, delineating their extent, and making these losses known and understood. Explaining all-encompassing loss means taking the *patient's* perspective and looking at what is lost. Loss resides in the chasm between the life once lived and current institutional existence. Participant D points out, 'I think, I don't think enough emphasis is placed on that fact that these people have lost their life. And basically through that they have perhaps experienced a huge range, huge range of losses and because of their behaviour they may have alienated people so that there

is just this massive aspect of loss that they all have.' Thus, loss can result in spiraling consequences. Awareness of losing one's life, one's way of being in the world causes patients enormous suffering that they may express through frustration, anger, and aggression, which leads to being rejected and further suffering, and subsequently more acting up. Misbehaving cloaks loss, and then, staff misread the patient's behavior. Conditions that exacerbate this process include the nature of the patient's impairment and its relative visibility, the extent to which it complicates daily life, and the institutional situation itself. To what extent does being subject to this situation impart messages that lapses in self-control are routine events and therefore desensitize patients as well as staff to troublesome behavior?

Explaining all-encompassing loss not only asks the listener to envision losses, but also to envision who a patient was before experiencing brain impairment. Thus, staff would gain a different image of the patient than that of the person they encounter in their daily work. Explaining links the past with the present and accounts for the present. (In contrast to Participant D's accounting for the present by looking at the past, Participant B considers impairment but concentrates on the present, not the magnitude of loss, nor the suffering it may cause.) Participant D adopts the role of the teacher who elucidates for the interviewer why patients act as they do. To what extent can or does she make her views known and heard? How does she deal with co-workers who fail to grasp these meanings of loss?

By explaining all-encompassing loss, Participant D presents herself as empathetic, insightful, and different – separate? – from co-workers. How does her empathy alter relationships with patients? How and when do her

insights affect her work with patients? What, if any, are the implications of setting oneself apart from co-workers in this setting?

From Tweed and Charmaz (2011, pp. 140–141).

The excerpt is filled with statements about loss. Trying to understand what Participant D is doing in her statements, however, provides considerably more grist for making comparisons and developing an analysis than if my codes only had noted loss.

Using the codes and statements in the data, I began with a working definition of what explaining all-encompassing loss meant. Then I started to spell out its properties and identify what seems to be crucial for staff members to share Participant's D's perspective: taking the patient's perspective and looking at their lives from this perspective. Participant D's statements and their corresponding codes bring awareness of multiple losses, biography and time into focus as well as present suffering and behavior. My point about patients' awareness of their losses leading to spiraling social and behavioral consequences rests on Participant D's statements and the codes of them. These codes give me a handle on how they fit with explaining all-encompassing loss and reveal sharp contrasts with Participant B's statements who emphasized the physical outbursts.

Is my analysis correct? A distant analyst whose standpoints and starting points reside outside the scene risks viewing actions and events out of context. Such risks increase when the data consist of extant texts and documents.

The questions at the end of the memo suggest that staff ideologies may affect *their* relationships as well as how they work with patients. These questions illustrate how early analytic threads might lead you in new directions – if you can seek the data that would inform these directions. If so, even a memo from a distanced standpoint can lead to weaving a fruitful analysis albeit one with contextual limitations.

In contrast, I had considerable contextual knowledge about the topic, research participant, and type of situation before writing the next memo, 'suffering as a moral status' (Box 7.7). My standpoints and starting points reflected 'insider' knowledge. I had collected data, interviewed the research participant several times, and had multiple involvements with the research topic for years before coding the specific interview that sparked writing the memo. The multiple forms of data provided immediate sources for comparative analysis.

This memo was quick but my thoughts leading to it were slow, as I imply in Chapter 6. From time to time, I had pondered Erving Goffman's (1963) powerful analysis of stigma. His concept has inundated social scientific and nursing literatures on chronic illness and disability. My research participants talked about situations in which they felt devalued and discredited, but somehow the concept of stigma did not quite represent all that I saw and heard. The pain and sorrow on their faces and in their voices cast deep shadows on their tales. Few people mentioned the term 'suffering' in reference to themselves; but their stories were replete with it. Nor did participants use the term 'moral status,' although it made sense of their experience.

The new code, 'suffering as a moral status,' ignited a new line of analysis and made sense of a substantial amount of data. In turn, having a reservoir of earlier transcribed interviews and recordings gave me the context from which I could construct the code and the memo about it. Had I not had these data, I would have missed liminal cues and nuanced statements. By treating 'suffering as a moral status' as a category, I raised a code to a conceptual level to treat analytically. I treat it as distinctive and constituted by properties that I discern in the data and synthesize by scrutinizing and compiling initial codes. Thus, I constructed this category, and developed an abstract analysis of it that stays close to my data.

BOX 7.7

Example of a Memo – Suffering as a Moral Status

Suffering is a profoundly *moral status* as well as a physical experience. Stories of suffering reflect and redefine that moral status.

With suffering come moral rights and entitlements as well as moral definitions – when suffering is deemed legitimate. Thus, the person can make certain moral claims *and* have certain moral judgments conferred upon him or her.

**Deserving
Dependent
In need**

Suffering can bring a person an elevated moral status. Here, suffering takes on a sacred status. This is a person who has been in sacred places, who has seen, known what ordinary people have not. Their stories are greeted with awe and wonder. The self also has elevated status. This person is special; the compelling story casts an aura of compelling qualities on the story-teller.

Ex. Bessie and her daughter. Bessie sat bent over in her wheelchair at the kitchen table and tells me of her rapid descent into life-threatening illness. When she began her tale of her risky surgery, her middle-aged daughter, Thelma, who had been tidying kitchen counters in the adjoining room, stops and joins us. Bessie tells of her near-death experience when her heart stopped. Thelma listened with rapt attention and awe. Though she had heard the tale many times before, it transformed the moment anew. Bessie told of being in the long dark tunnel, then seeing a beautiful bright light. Bessie believed that the light emanated from the face of God. As Thelma heard her mother's tale again, she gazed

upon her with reverence. Afterwards, Thelma emphasized how this event had lifted Bessie's spirits and improved her attitude toward her illness.

Suffering also may present opportunities to play out the myth of the hero who emerges victorious against all odds. Thus again, suffering elevates status and sets the person apart when viewed as a hero who has emerged from battle. This person has defied death and, perhaps, doctors through resolving to act despite taking risks. Heroic status often follows facing illness and death earlier than one's peers. Such stories then become tales that entice and proclaim. They entice an audience and they proclaim a changed identity. Both person and circumstance are transformed through the heroic struggle.

Although suffering may first confer an elevated moral status, views change. The moral claims from suffering typically narrow in scope and in power. The circles of significance shrink. Stories of self within these moral claims may entrance and entertain for a while, but grow thin over time – unless someone has considerable influence or power. The circles narrow to most significant others.

The moral claims of suffering may only supersede those of the healthy and whole in crisis and its immediate aftermath. Otherwise, the person is less. WORTH LESS. Two words – now separate may change as illness and aging take their toll. They may end up as 'worthless.'

The moral status of suffering brings standards of decorum and dignity. One has to live up to these standards or suffer the consequences. However, the standards are usually taken-for-granted and relative to group and prior experience. Invoking the standards of one group can alienate another.

Christine went from silence to outburst. Silence doesn't work in some contexts; it's the only strategy in others. An outburst does attract attention, but can alienate.

The ill person may also take for granted standards that are or are not shared. One's moral status may emerge in private with spouse, parent, or adult child. It may occur in public as degradation. A groundskeeper had worked as part of a maintenance team for years with the same men. They had shared an esprit de corps. But now his work-mates refused to help him on the very tasks that they had always been defined as two- or three-men jobs. A professor in an understaffed department suffered a rapid decline that resulted in his colleagues taking over his classes. Though they said they did so willingly, he sensed how burdened they were and felt that he had let them down. Meanwhile his colleagues banged at the Dean's door, saying 'How can we get him out of here?'

Christine makes moral claims, not only befitting those of suffering, but of PERSONHOOD. She is a person who has a right to be heard, a right to just and fair treatment in both the medical arena and the workplace. (memo 1-04-98)

The memo in Box 7.7 outlines ideas and initiates discussion between them. I tried to jot down quickly everything that came to mind about the category, codes, and data. Ideas for the category came to me when I was coding data while traversing the continent by plane, so I stopped to write them. As I was scribbling, the links between suffering and moral status became clearer. I said to myself, of course, this is what I've been trying to grapple with; why didn't I think of it sooner? I jotted down the short memo and typed it when I returned home. I copied my earlier capital letters and spacing and used boldface in lieu of

my yellow felt-tip marker. (I use visual strategies to emphasize ideas from the start.) That way I gave myself some prompts and flagged leads to pursue. A few additions clarified points.

In the memo, I first established 'suffering as a moral status' as a category I aimed to analyze. I claimed that we need to think beyond physical pain and agony and look into moral life and moral worth. Hence, I formed a working definition of suffering as making a person's moral status problematic. Research participants dwelled on moral tales of loss and its stigmatizing consequences. The tone and body language of their telling expressed suffering and meaning, sometimes more than their words. Still, participants' tales also contained tacit claims for moral rights and legitimate moral status.

Which codes did the category 'suffering as a moral status' subsume? How did these codes fit together under the category? I saw that the category subsumed a number of initial codes that implied devaluation and the participant's response to experiences in which they felt demeaned, disbelieved, or discriminated against. I began to connect conceptions of rights, claims, and injustice with both suffering and moral status. Writing the memo helped me to clarify how moral status changes in suffering. It prompted me to look further at the conditions under which moral status rises as well as those when it plummets. I began to lay out a moral hierarchy of suffering and to ferret out how implicit rules affect someone's status in this moral hierarchy. The memo encouraged me to go back and forth between data and my emerging analysis and to relate it to other categories.

The memo contains ideas and several stories but its purpose needed fleshing out. I had been comparing situations between various research participants for some years. Recall Christine Danforth's story in Chapter 6. The focused coding in Box 6.4 generated several potential categories, 'suffering as a moral status,' 'making a moral claim,' and 'having a devalued moral status' (Charmaz, 1999, 2001). Over the years, Christine had told stark stories of her struggles to remain independent, to

manage her illness, and to have a place in the world. Several major incidents inflamed Christine's sense of moral outrage about her treatment and ignited growing concern about her moral rights. These incidents not only aroused her sense of injustice but also undermined her sense of self.

In the memo, I define suffering as including social responses and I assert the relationship of this definition to self. Many people I talked with realized that other people – including professionals and family members – denied or doubted the presence and/or extent of their symptoms. These participants told stories of their attempts to be treated as persons with legitimate concerns. As you could see in Bonnie Presley's story (Box 5.2) of delaying disclosure in Chapter 5, whether and when someone discloses illness affects how other people view and treat them. Suffering can take a further twist. Receiving second-hand news can hurt loved ones and cause them to suffer. Thus, legitimacy, disclosure, fairness, and suffering become intertwined.

To which kind of theoretical analysis does the category of 'suffering as a moral status' belong? What types of conceptual connections does the memo suggest? It certainly speaks to structure, process, and experience. The notion of status assumes structure. In this case it assumes a hierarchical stratifying of social value. Structure remains implicit in the memo but I assert its presence – and its implications. Note how holding high moral status compares with low. I point out the tenuousness of high moral status and imply how it deteriorates. This process holds profound implications for self and identity. It stirs people's emotions, affects their identities, redefines their situations, and changes relationships. The category integrates disparate, as well as similar experiences, implies temporal ordering and turning points, fosters certain behaviors, fits into and emerges under certain conditions, and has consequences.

This memo hints at how sensitizing concepts, long left silent, may murmur during coding and analysis. Faint echoes of Talcott Parsons (1953), Erving Goffman (1959, 1961, 1963, 1967) and

Emile Durkheim (1915/1965, 1925/1961, 1951), who inspired Goffman, reverberate through the memo. Parsons's conception of the sick role lingers in the background but affects the moral position from which moral expectations and edicts flow. No doubt Goffman's treatment of moral life and moral meanings throughout his opus informed and furthered my connections between moral hierarchies, moral status within them, and suffering. I had not reviewed these theorists before writing the memo, nor thought about them when doing it. We can, however, discern how the memo complements several of their ideas. Both Goffman and Durkheim wrestle with moral rules, moral rights, and moral responsibilities. Goffman dealt extensively with how people presented themselves to others, managed impressions that others might have, and played roles during interactions. For Goffman, situations have their own moral rules and people aim to establish themselves as moral beings within them. Durkheim's analysis of the moral force of rules and of meanings of the sacred and profane illuminates the hidden strength of social bonds and shared values.

HIGH MORAL STATUS – VALIDATED MORAL CLAIMS

MEDICAL EMERGENCY
INVOLUNTARY ONSET
BLAMELESSNESS FOR CONDITION

SUSTAINED MORAL STATUS – ACCEPTED MORAL CLAIMS

CHRONIC ILLNESS
NEGOTIATED DEMANDS
PRESENT OR PAST POWER & RECIPROCITIES

DIMINISHED MORAL STATUS – QUESTIONABLE MORAL CLAIMS

PERSONAL VALUE

worth less

worth less

Worth Less

WORTHLESS

Figure 7.1 Hierarchy of Moral Status in Suffering

Because I chose this memo for a spoken address, I wanted the audience to hear the links between my ideas and the stories that gave rise to them. I also wanted them to envision the suffering that follows loss of moral status. By the time I presented the material 5 weeks after drafting the memo, I had articulated an explicit moral hierarchy. Figure 7.1 depicts this moral hierarchy as a structure and shows movement down it. As moral status plummets, worthlessness enshrouds many people with debilitating chronic illnesses.

The life of an initial memo can outlast its publication. Further analysis and development of the ideas can generate additional works. One memo can spark numerous ideas and serve varied purposes. The journal articles in which memos appear can presage books. Since publication of the address, I have refined some of my ideas about suffering to reflect how definitions of difference in my data accelerated individuals' descent down the hierarchy. As I compared incidents in my data, I learned more about how class and age differences and appearances played out in interaction and appeared in the hierarchy (see Charmaz, 2005). As you gather further data, you may find valuable sources of comparisons that you had not anticipated. My data contained numerous examples of individuals who had lost credibility as reliable adults when their medical practitioners did not accept their symptoms as real. In Box 5.4 a patient recounts her story of finding herself in the care of a new psychiatrist who discounted her claims of having lupus erythematosus and thus needing to wear dark glasses. Her situation exemplifies conditions under which a person rapidly loses credibility and

worth (see Charmaz 2005, p. 368).

In short, an earlier memo can inform and refine later analyses. By writing memos, you will also become more attune to actions and statements in your data.

Begin your memo by titling it. That's easy because your codes give you titles to analyze; hence, you already have direction and focus. Define the category you intend to treat. Note how I tried to define why and how suffering is a moral status. Take your definition as far as you can. Forming the definition from your codes and data forces you to pierce the surface. Although you may establish a preliminary, working definition to get a handle on the phenomena, grappling with your material moves the definition beyond description into analysis. Thus, your definition of the category starts by explicating its properties or characteristics.

Next, think about where both the category and the data it subsumes lead you. Follow these leads, whatever they might be. I look for the underlying and – usually – unstated assumptions embedded in the category. In addition, I try to show how and when the category develops and changes and why and for whom it has relevance in the field setting. I found that people frequently referred to living one day at a time when they suffered a medical crisis or faced continued uncertainty. Subsequently, I began to ask questions about what living one day at a time was like for them. I began to define the category and its characteristics from their responses and from published autobiographical accounts. The term 'living one day at a time' condenses a series of implicit meanings and assumptions. It becomes a strategy for handling unruly feelings, for exerting some control over a now uncontrollable life, for facing

uncertainty, and for handling a conceivably foreshortened future.

Memo-writing encourages you to dig into implicit, unstated, and condensed meanings. Look for codes that subsume condensed meanings. These codes give you analytic mileage and carry conceptual weight. Such codes can give your nascent analysis increasing theoretical centrality and direction. See how I tried to get at these meanings in the section of a longer memo shown in Box 7.8.

BOX 7.8

Treating an *In Vivo* Code as a Category

Living One Day at a Time

Living one day at a time means dealing with illness on a day-to-day basis, holding future plans and even ordinary activities in abeyance while the person and, often, others deal with illness. When living one day at a time, the person feels that his or her future remains unsettled, that he or she cannot foresee the future or if there will be a future. Living one day at a time allows the person to focus on illness, treatment and regimen without becoming entirely immobilized by fear or future implications. By concentrating on the present, the person can avoid or minimize thinking about death and the possibility of dying.

Relation to Time Perspective

The felt need to live one day at a time often drastically alters a person's time perspective. Living one day at a time pulls the person into the present and pushes back past futures (the futures the person projected before illness or before this round of illness) so that they recede without mourning [their loss]. These past futures can slip

away, perhaps almost unnoticed. [I then go and compare three respondents' situations, statements, and time perspectives.]

Memo-writing frees you to explore your ideas about your categories. Memo-writing is part of the discovery phase of writing in which you first write to learn. Treat memos as partial, preliminary, and provisional. They are entirely correctable. Just note where you stand on firm ground and where you make conjectures. Then go back to the field and check your conjectures.

Begin writing memos as soon as you have some ideas and categories to pursue. If at a loss about what to write, elaborate on and compare your most frequent codes. Keep collecting data, keep coding, and keep refining your ideas through writing more and further developed memos. Some researchers who use grounded theory methods discover a few interesting findings early in their data collection and then truncate their research. Their work lacks the 'intimate familiarity' with the setting or experience that Lofland and Lofland (1995) avow meets the standards for good qualitative research. Glaser (2001) rightly applauds Martin Jankowski's (1991) concept of 'defiant individualism' among gang members, because Jankowski has compared hundreds of incidents.⁵ Cover your topic in depth by exploring sufficient cases and by elaborating

your categories fully.

Memos can remain private and unshared. At this point, just get your ideas down as quickly and clearly as you can. Do not worry about verb tense, overuse of prepositional phrases, or lengthy sentences at this point. You write memos to render the data, not to communicate to an audience. Use memo-writing to discover and explore ideas. You can revise the memo later.

Writing memos quickly without editing them fosters developing and preserving your natural voice. Then your memo reads as though written by a living, thinking, feeling human being rather than a pedantic social scientist. You can write memos at different levels of abstraction – from the concrete to the highly theoretical. Some of your memos will find their way directly into your first draft of your analysis. Set aside others with a different focus and develop them later.

Much of your memo-writing will be concerned with making comparisons, in keeping with Glaser and Strauss's constant comparative methods. Constructing core categories through the constant comparison method is fundamental for doing grounded theory. Lillemor Hallberg (2006) declares that making constant comparisons is 'the "core category" of grounded theory' (p.141). She writes that the constant comparative method means:

That every part of data, i.e. emerging codes, categories, properties, and dimensions as well as different parts of the data, are constantly compared with all other parts of the data to explore variations, similarities and differences in data. The constant comparative method of grounded theory is strict enough to be helpful to the researcher in exploring the content and meaning in the data, but not saddled with so many strict rules to be too rigid for a grounded theory researcher. (p. 143)

Memo-writing is the site in which you develop earlier comparisons and make new ones. Making constant comparisons through memo-writing can lead to defining and

developing a core category that otherwise may have eluded you. In your successive memos, you can compare incidents indicated by each category, integrate categories by comparing them and delineating their relationships, delimit the scope and range of the emerging theory by comparing categories with concepts and write the theory, which you may compare with other theories in the same area of study. Hence, you may begin by elaborating the codes in which you compared one respondent's beliefs, stance, and actions with another respondent's, or one experience with another. If you have longitudinal data, you can compare a participant's response, experience, or situation at one point in time with that at another time. Then as you become more analytic and have some tentative analytic categories, compare new data with them. This step will help you delimit your categories and to define their properties.

As you develop categories, write further memos to detail comparisons between them. These memos help you to tease out distinctions that sharpen your treatment of the material. Such memos also aid you to weigh and locate your categories in relation to each other. Through memo-writing, you distinguish between major and minor categories and delineate how they are related. Thus, you begin to frame them into a theoretical statement. You direct the shape and form of your emergent analysis through your memos.

Bring your data right into your analysis with each new, revised, or elaborated memo. That way you keep your memos grounded while making them more analytic and abstract. *Show*

how you build your analysis on your data in each memo. Bringing your data into successive levels of memo-writing ultimately saves time. You do not have to dig through stacks of material to illustrate your points and, moreover, your analysis builds on its inductive foundation.

In the section of a memo provided in Box 7.8, note that I first defined the category, 'living one day at a time,' and outlined its main properties. Then I developed aspects of living one day at a time such as its relationship to time perspective, which I show in the excerpt, and to managing emotions. The memo also covered *how* people lived one day at a time, the problems it posed as well as those it solved, and the consequences of doing so.

Memo-writing helps you to:

- **Stop and think about your data**
- **Treat qualitative codes as categories to analyze**
- **Continue to interact with your data and emerging analysis**
- **Develop your writer's voice and writing rhythm (let your memos read like letters to a close friend; no need for stodgy academic prose)**
- **Spark ideas to check out in the field setting**
- **Avoid forcing your data into extant concepts and theories**
- **Construct fresh ideas, create new concepts, and find novel relationships**

- **Demonstrate connections between categories (e.g. empirical events and social structures, larger groups and the individual, espoused beliefs and actions)**
- **Discover gaps in your data collection**
- **Link data-gathering with data analysis and report-writing**
- **Build whole sections of papers and chapters**
- **Keep involved in research and writing**
- **Maintain analytic momentum**
- **Increase your confidence and competence.**

Adopting Writers' Strategies: Prewriting Exercises

Delving into memo-writing can be liberating. Memo-writing can release you from the strictures of academic writing, the constraints of traditional research procedures, and the controls of teachers and supervisors. But does it? Not always. Some problems arise from within the researcher, others from without. Researchers occasionally find that the freedom of memo-writing involves a disquieting leap of faith and practice. Memo-writing requires us to *tolerate ambiguity*. Researchers who write from an outline with a predictable beginning, middle, and end may move right into reporting and miss the discovery, exploratory phase of writing. Memo-writing exemplifies this discovery phase. Subsequently, these researchers cannot write until they have the whole picture in mind. They wait – and wait. Other people view writing as tedious drudgery. They dawdle and dread it.⁶

If either dawdling or dreading sounds like you, try building prewriting exercises into your analytic practices to help you learn to tolerate ambiguity – and to enjoy writing. Prewriting exercises consist of strategies that writers use; they are not part of the methods associated with grounded theory. These exercises can, however, help you delve into writing your grounded theory memos. You may use them as unrelated warm-up exercises or as tools to help you begin memo-writing.

Teachers and research supervisors often treat grounded theory memos as interim, but sharable reports, rather than as private analytic explorations. Thus, another scenario can stifle your efforts to write memos: that is, being evaluated on their quality. How can you write spontaneous memos subject to scrutiny when their purpose is for personal analytic building blocks? Your memos likely will lose spontaneity and their creative edge. When a watchful eye stares – or glares – over your shoulder, it may take you forever to draft a memo.

From their perspectives, teachers and research supervisors have good reasons for evaluating your memos. Many students can handle a large, unwieldy project when their teachers divide it into steps. This pedagogical strategy fits traditional quantitative research design and much of qualitative research, but not memo-writing.

The problem now extends to the professional realm. Increasingly, research teams on large funded projects choose grounded theory methods. Collaborative research projects depend on sharing tasks and ideas. Principal investigators expect team members to prove their merit. What better way to see how team members demonstrate merit than through their memos? How can team members collaborate if they do not share their emerging analyses? Yet this kind of situation poses other pressing questions for you. How can you avoid being stifled, complete tasks on time, and preserve your analytic autonomy?

Again, consider starting with prewriting exercises. They can get you started and make memo-writing easier. You can revise your memos later for clarity and organization. Intriguing software programs are available to help you generate ideas, although other techniques consist of simple exercises only requiring paper and pencils. For many years, I have introduced two prewriting exercises, *clustering* and *freewriting*, in grounded theory workshops.⁷ Both blocked and fluent workshop participants have found these exercises useful ways to get started and to rethink ideas and how they fit together. Peter

Elbow's (1981) guidelines for freewriting resemble aspects of memo-writing but do not limit you to the data. Both clustering and freewriting are non-linear and thus liberate you from linear logic and organization.

Clustering

Clustering is a shorthand prewriting technique for getting started. As Gabriele Rico (1983) explains, clustering gives you a non-linear, visual, and flexible technique to understand and organize your material. Adopt this technique to produce a tentative and alterable chart or map of your work. Like freewriting, a major objective of clustering is to liberate your creativity. You write your central idea, category, or process; then circle it and draw spokes from it to smaller circles to show its defining properties, and their relationships and relative significance.

Because it offers a diagram of relationships, clustering shares some similarities with conceptual or situational mapping in grounded theory (see Clarke, 2003, 2005; Clarke & Friese, 2007; Soulliere, Britt, & Maines, 2001). The configurations of clusters provide an image of how your topic fits together and relates to other phenomena. Clustering is active, quick, and changeable. You can remain uncommitted to a cluster. Try several different clusters to see how the pieces of your puzzle fit together in a variety of ways. This form of prewriting gives you a fast self-correcting way to work with ideas. Clustering makes writing less onerous for those who dread it and speeds up the process for those who enjoy it. Novices find that clustering expedites laying out the form and content of their memos.

Through clustering you gain control because you create an image of the piece before delving into writing about it. Putting together a sensible cluster can give a novice confidence to start elaborating the various sections of it. Clustering can give you a preliminary sketch of the memo you need to write. Later, you can use clustering to work out how sections of your paper fit together.

You can use clustering for all kinds of writing tasks at varied levels of analytic work. The general approach to clustering includes the directions below. You might follow a few of these directions when you first explore your codes.

- **Start with the main topic or idea at the center**
- **Work quickly**
- **Move out from the nucleus into smaller subclusters**
- **Keep all related material in the same subcluster**
- **Make the connections clear between each idea, code, and/or category**
- **Keep branching out until you have exhausted your knowledge**
- **Try several different clusters on the same topic**
- **Use clustering to play with your material.**

A nucleus word, such as a code, forms the most basic cluster. Try to construct the cluster and see where it takes you. Clustering around processes moves you further into studying actions rather than only structures. Try to draw connections between parts of your emerging pattern. When you finish, you have a plan for proceeding. Whether or not you follow your plan, you have created a way of moving in and through the material. For practice, try clustering topics unrelated to your research or writing. Explore your thoughts about an event, a film, or a book.

Treat clustering as inconsequential to lessen the seriousness of writing. If it helps you play with your material, so much the better. Writers use clustering to combat writing blocks. Clustering can get you started and keep you moving. The spontaneity and imagery in clustering can foster developing feeling, imagery, and rhythm when you begin to write.

Clustering can enable you to define essentials. It allows for chaos and prompts you to create paths through it. You gain a way of sifting and sorting your material while you create a pattern about, around, and through your category or categories.

Clustering lets you make what lurks in the background jump into the foreground. Use clustering to make things explicit and to order your ideas. A cluster provides a direct visual, as contrasted with a solely mental image. Hence, you can assess the relative importance of the points within your cluster and relationships between them.

Clustering techniques are fast, fluid, fruitful – and fun. If they help you, adopt them. I have adapted these techniques to use with grounded theory methods. You may wish to start clustering with one code and then move on to clustering relationships between codes and then codes and categories. In any case, try the general approach to clustering as outlined above or my adaptation below. After working on a cluster for 8–10 minutes, you will sense how to begin writing about the category. Then you can begin writing a focused freewrite or a memo.

The following are *guidelines for clustering*, and Figure 7.2 offers an example.

- **Draw a circle around a main code large enough to include what it indicates**
- **Make the circled code the center of *this* cluster**
- **Divide the inside of the circle to show the defining properties of the code**
- **Draw spokes from your code to any codes it subsumes to signify relationships**
- **Use configurations of clusters to construct an image of how your main codes fit together and relate to other categories**
- **Make the size of your circled codes reflect their relative empirical strength**
- **Indicate the relative strength of the relationships between codes by the width of your lines**
- **Allow your clusters to be non-linear**
- **Work quickly and keep involved in the process**

- **Take a cluster as far as you can**
- **Treat clustering as flexible, mutable, and open-ended**
- **Keep clustering. Try several on the same codes. Compare them.**

Freewriting

Freewriting means putting pen to paper or fingers to keyboard and writing for 8 minutes to begin, longer with practice. Freewriting encourages you to compose fresh material, unlearn past immobilizing habits, and write in a natural voice. Freewriting liberates your thoughts and feelings. It provides an effective warm-up exercise and produces results: a freewrite. A quick 10-minute freewrite may save you hours of staring at a blank screen.

Writing teachers often urge students to use freewriting for free association – write whatever comes to consciousness. This type of freewriting opens our minds and releases our imaginations. Such freewriting can increase our receptivity to the world and our ease in writing. It releases immobilizing constraints that others place on you and you may have internalized. Regular sessions of this freewriting can help your writing flow and heighten your awareness of feeling and imagery.

How do you freewrite? Try following these guidelines:

- **Get your ideas down on paper as quickly and fully as you can**
- **Write to and for yourself**
- **Permit yourself to write freely and badly**
- **Don't attend to grammar, organization, logic, evidence, and audience**
- **Write as though you are talking.**

Be receptive when freewriting. Accept anything that comes to mind. Keep writing – putting one thing down on paper leads to

another. Let the process emerge. Follow those glimpses of ideas and bursts of inchoate thoughts – right now. You can assess them later. Just concentrate on what you learn or sense now.

Correct grammar doesn't matter. Neither do perfect spelling, logical organization, and clear arguments. What does matter is that you become accustomed to getting your ideas on paper, however they emerge. A freewrite is for your eyes only, like a secret journal you create and share with yourself.

Once you are comfortable with freewriting, try a focused freewrite that addresses your data and categories. To help you remain open, follow the guidelines above. Doing focused freewrites can keep you from becoming immobilized and may serve as a direct precursor to memo-writing. Study these freewrites because they may contain seeds of a great memo. By adding a step or two to the writing process, you may soon be writing fluent memos for your research project.

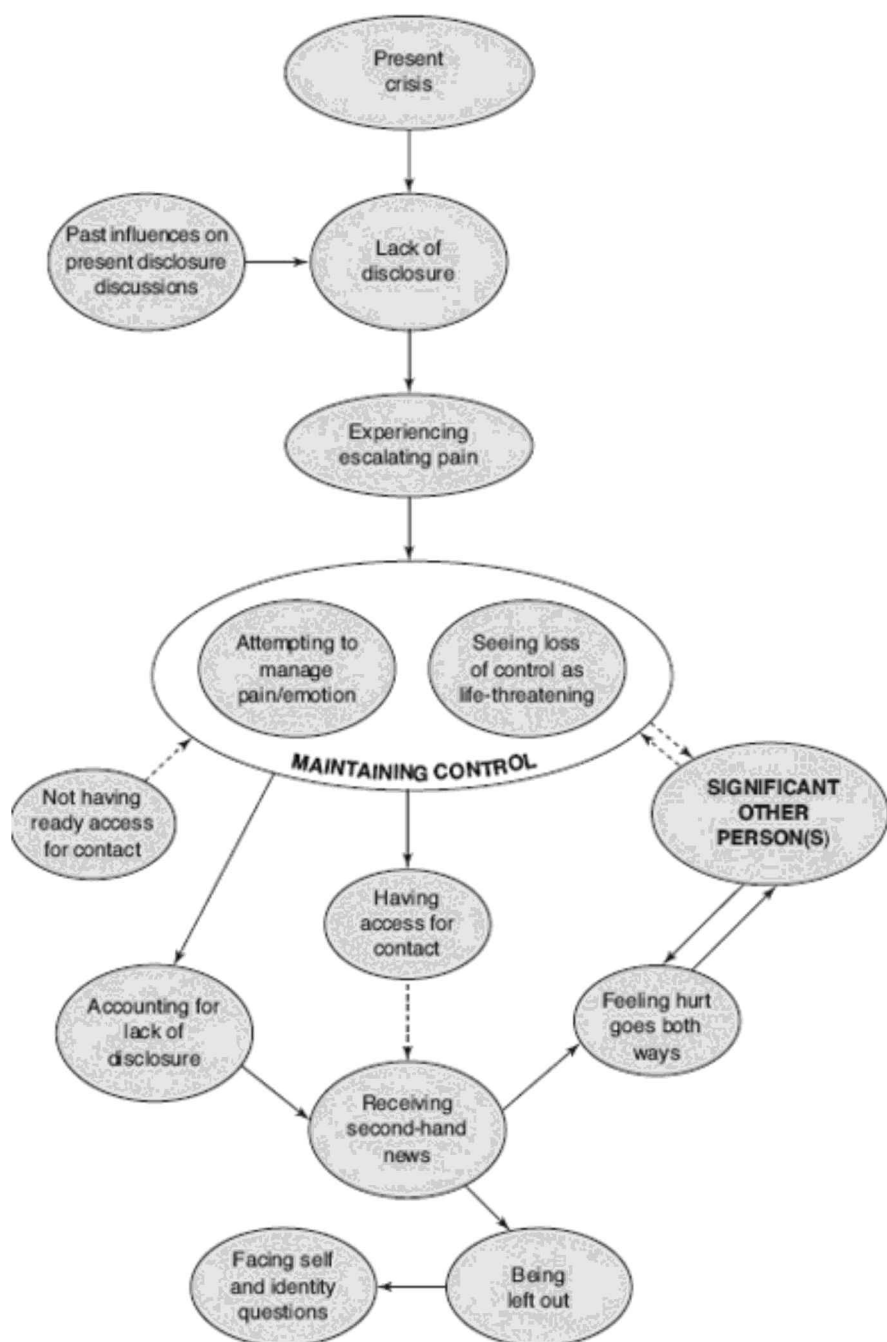


Figure 7.2 ‘Example of Clustering’

Work in whatever way suits your style – with pad and pencil or your computer.

In Box 7.9, I took the clustering that I made from Bonnie Presley’s interview excerpt and wrote about it for about 12 minutes. See the excerpt below from this focused freewrite. Note that I brought other data right into the freewrite; the act of writing about the codes sparked comparisons with other research participants. This focused freewrite is considerably more coherent than my freewrites often are, in part because I completed the clustering first and in part because I find writing from data easier than other forms of writing. The clustering helped me to draw relationships between several intriguing codes and Bonnie’s situation. Clustering is particularly helpful to those of us who gravitate to images. Many writers freewrite first or use both techniques. Experiment with freewriting and clustering and see what works for you.

BOX 7.9

Example of a Focused Freewrite on Codes from Bonnie Presley’s Interview

The crisis sets off the chain of events and dilemmas about disclosure. Yet the past history of relationships and issues around disclosure echo in the current crisis. Lack of disclosure may be an explicit choice or a consequence of other actions or inactions. Various participants will make assumptions about the person’s lack of disclosure, how long it prevailed and what it ‘really’ meant. In Bonnie’s case, her lack of disclosure coincided with escalating pain and her increased efforts to manage, to cope, to control what was happening. If so, then disclosing implied risks of losing control if all the past conflict, disappointments, and lack of emotional support arise again. In other situations such as Bob’s,

disclosing meant possibly reinvoking all the past issues about obtaining help and his embarrassment – and mortification for asking for it. Such issues in disclosure raise all kinds of sticky intimacy issues and relationship obligations anew. Bob defines not asking for help unless absolutely necessary as his relationship obligation; Bonnie sees avoiding emotional upheavals with her daughter as hers.

In some sense then, Bob only has partial and tentative access for help and partial access for contact. It is not a given. Bonnie has access for contact although she has to be proactive to realize it. Amy comes by or calls sporadically; she is not a regular part of Bonnie's day, as Linda has become. This incident with Bonnie shows how feeling hurt goes two ways. Misunderstandings build on each other.

From the family or friend's view, receiving second-hand news informs one of his or her place and significance. Being left out stings. It elicits unwelcome images of self and the relationship. It may reaffirm family hierarchies and past family feuds as in Ann's case. Identity questions emerge.

Using Memos to Raise Focused Codes to Conceptual Categories

Writing memos on your codes from the start helps to clarify what is happening in the field. In grounded theory, memo-writing relies on treating some codes as conceptual categories to analyze. Glaser and Strauss (1967, p. 37) define a category as a 'conceptual element in a theory.' Yet what stands as a category? But what does that mean? No need to worry: you already have your focused codes, as I note above.

Through engaging in focused coding, you begin to sketch the content and form of your budding analysis. Treating focused

codes as tentative categories prompts you to develop and scrutinize them. Then you can evaluate these tentative categories and decide whether they hold up as categories for *this* analysis. If you accept these codes as categories, clarify what they consist of and specify the relationships between them.



To begin, assess which codes best represent what you see happening in your data. In a memo, raise them to conceptual categories for your developing analytic framework – give them conceptual definition and analytical treatment in narrative form in your memo. Thus, you go beyond using a code as a descriptive tool to view and synthesize data.

What do categories do? Categories explicate ideas, events, or processes in your data – and do so in telling words. A category may subsume common themes and patterns in several codes. For example, my category ‘regaining a valued self’ included ‘drawing on lessons from the past,’ ‘discovering an audible voice,’ ‘learning to live with uncertainty’ and ‘realizing the dream’ (Charmaz, 2011a, pp. 189–195).

Again, make your categories as conceptual as possible – with abstract power, general reach, analytic direction, and precise wording. Simultaneously, remain consistent with your data and acknowledge the temporal, social, and situational conditions of their production. By having made your focused codes active, incisive (to reflect what people are doing or what

is happening), and brief, you have the material to treat them as potential categories. During coding you asked, what category does this piece of data indicate? Now ask, what category does this code indicate? A little time and distance from collecting data and initial coding may help you to move another conceptual step. Processes gain visibility when you keep codes active. Succinct, focused codes lead to sharp, clear categories. That way, you can establish criteria for your categories to make further comparisons.

Grounded theorists look for substantive processes that they develop from their codes. 'Getting off the street' (Karabanow, 2008), 'managing "spoiled" national identity' (Rivera, 2008) and 'living one day at a time' above are such processes. As grounded theorists create conceptual handles to explain what is happening in the setting, they may move toward defining generic processes (Prus, 1987). A generic process cuts across different empirical settings and problems; it can be applied to varied substantive areas. The process of regaining a valued self extends beyond devastating illness and injury. It can also occur when people lose jobs, intimate partners, and homes. For sociologists, generic processes are basic to social life; for psychologists, generic processes are fundamental for psychological existence; for anthropologists, these processes support local and global cultures. Because they are fundamental, generic processes can apply in varied professions and fields. A grounded theorist can elaborate and refine the generic process by gathering more data from diverse arenas where this process is evident. Concentrate on analyzing a generic process that you define in your codes; then you can raise relevant codes to theoretical categories that lead to explanations of the process and predictions concerning these categories.⁸ As you raise a code to a category, you begin to write narrative statements in memos that:

- **Define the category**
- **Explicate the properties of the category**

- **Specify the conditions under which the category arises, is maintained, and changes**
- **Describe its consequences**
- **Show how this category relates to other categories.**

Categories may consist of *in vivo* codes that you take directly from your respondents' discourse or they may represent your theoretical or substantive definition of what is happening in the data. My terms (Charmaz, 1991a) 'good days and bad days' and 'living one day at a time' came directly from my respondents' voices. In contrast, my categories 'recapturing the past' and 'time in immersion and immersion in time' reflect theoretical definitions of actions and events. In the same study, categories such as 'pulling in,' 'facing dependency,' and 'making trade-offs' address my respondents' substantive realities of grappling with a serious illness. I created these codes and used them as categories but they reflect my research participants' concerns and actions. Novice researchers may find that they rely almost exclusively on *in vivo* and substantive codes. A grounded description often results rather than a theory. Nonetheless, studying how these codes fit together in categories can help you treat them more theoretically.

By writing memos on your focused codes, you build and clarify your category by examining all the data it covers and by identifying variations within it and between other categories. You also become aware of gaps in your analysis. For example, I developed my category 'existing from day to day' when I realized that my category 'living one day at a time' did not cover impoverished people's level of desperation. In short, I had data about a daily struggle to survive that the first category, 'living one day at a time,' did not subsume. Box 7.10 provides the first few paragraphs of the finished narrative:

BOX 7.10

Example of a Memo Prompted by Studying an

Earlier Memo – The Category of ‘Existing from Day to Day’

Existing from day to day occurs when a person plummets into continued crises that rip life apart. It reflects a loss of control of health and the wherewithal to keep life together.

Existing from day to day means constant struggle for daily survival. Poverty and lack of support contribute to and complicate that struggle. Hence, poor and isolated people usually plummet further and faster than affluent individuals with concerned families. Loss of control extends to being unable to obtain necessities – food, shelter, heat, medical care.

The struggle to exist keeps people in the present, especially if they have continued problems in getting the basic necessities that middle-class adults take for granted. Yet other problems can assume much greater significance for these people than their illness – a violent husband, a runaway child, an alcoholic spouse, the overdue rent.

Living one day at a time differs from existing from day to day. Living one day at a time provides a strategy for controlling emotions, managing life, dimming the future, and getting through a troublesome period. It involves managing stress, illness, or regimen, and dealing with these things each day to control them as best as one can. It means concentrating on the here and now and relinquishing other goals, pursuits, and obligations. (Charmaz, 1991a, p. 185)

Note the comparisons between the two categories above. To generate categories through focused coding, you need to compare data, incidents, contexts, and categories. Try making such comparisons as suggested in the section on ‘advanced

memos' in Box 7.4.

Some examples might help. Carolyn Wiener (2000) compares how professional providers, health care managers, and industry regulators define quality care and accountability for it. I compare individuals' depictions of events and their responses to them at different times (an advantage of comparing material from sequential interviews is that you can compile respondents' stories about their recent events rather than ones reconstructed from long-past incidents). In addition to comparing events and incidents, I also compared how people experience different phases of their illnesses.

As I compared different people's experiences, I realized that some people's situations forced them into the present. I then looked at how my rendering of living one day at a time did not apply to them. I reviewed earlier interviews and began to seek published accounts of illness narratives that might clarify the comparison. As is evident in the distinctions between 'living one day at a time' and 'existing from day to day', focused coding prompts you to begin to see the relationships and patterns between categories.

Concluding Thoughts

Your memos will form the core of your grounded theory. Following up on ideas and questions that came up while you wrote them will push your work forward. Now you can set aside those memos that you deem to be finished and work on those that still raise nagging questions. Memos provide a record of your research and of your analytic progress. Do keep a memo bank containing each one so that you have the chronological set and can retrieve an earlier idea that you had discarded. You can revisit, review, and revise your memos with a critical eye as you proceed. Like me, you may find that a little time and distance allows gaps and holes in your memos to appear. On returning to them you may identify your next step in an instant and, moreover, take your ideas to a more abstract analytic level.

Perhaps more often than solving our analytic problems, studying our memos – particularly early memos – points to gaps we need to fill. Our ideas are tentative and the memos reveal that we need to do more work to strengthen our categories. When we realize that our categories are weak or incomplete, we can seek more data, but how do we do that? Which data should we seek? How will this new material solve our analytic problems? The next chapter will show you how grounded theorists grapple with these problems and often solve them. Plan to return to the empirical world. In the meantime, keep writing memos.

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- 1 These properties define the loss of self that Teresa experienced and serve to define the category 'losing a valued self.' I chose not to present them as formal properties because I wished to reproduce the power of the experience in the writing of it.
 - 2 For memos that make quick preliminary comments and converse with a co-author, see Anselm Strauss's (1987, pp. 111–112) memo.
 - 3 Researchers who do not share professional ideologies with their research participants may present views that contrast with those of researchers who do. One striking example is evident in sociologist Daniel Chambliss's (1996) observations of nursing practice in his award-winning ethnographic study. He takes a critical view on how nurses perform their daily work. Certainly the form of data collection also contributes to such differences. Chambliss based his analysis on 10 years of ethnographic study while most qualitative research relies on interviewing, and limited one-shot interviewing at that. As I. E. Seidman (2006) points out, professionals excel at articulating a persuasive but idealized view of their fields. He advocates interviewing professionals three times as a way of getting beyond the standardized public relations performance they offer in an initial interview.

- 4 In this sense, grounded theorists include fewer field anecdotes and less description than other qualitative approaches. We often fragment actions, events, and participants' stories in service of our developing analyses. Glaser (1998) lauds such fragmentation as necessary to move the theory forward. Some narrative analysts, phenomenologists, and postmodernists object to fracturing participants' stories into fragments because they believe the story needs to be preserved (although often in condensed form) in its wholeness and that the form the story takes, as well as its content, provides significant insight into its meaning.
- 5 Glaser (2001) clarifies his stance on comparing incidents with incidents when he argues that small sample size does not mean limited incidents because people can talk at length and be reinterviewed. Whether and how well his logic works in actual practice is an empirical question. Telling incidents become evident during data-gathering and analysis but may not affect all participants, thereby limiting the range of comparisons. Because many grounded theory studies rely on single interviews, researchers may only learn about a participant's one major incident rather than a range of incidents that might offer sources of comparison. In addition, they lose the chance to ask more questions later about the incident of original interest. An ethnography with a small number of participants but many observations such as Curtis Jackson-Jacobs's (2004) study of college crack users can generate numerous incidents for comparative analysis.
- 6 Don't castigate yourself. Some good writers procrastinate, then inch along, word by word. You may be absorbing the material at a preconscious level and need that time to have your ideas come together. Just try to flow with the process, recognize your patterns, and, if need be, build in some steps and strategies that help you move forward.
- 7 Those of us who have taught courses on writing routinely include these techniques. For more ideas and excellent

advice, see Ede (2011) and Flower (2003).

- 8 Dey (1999) is correct in arguing that categorization in grounded theory is more complex and problematic than its originators suggest. I agree with Dey that categorization involves inferences as well as classification.